

**May You and Your Loved Ones Be
Inscribed For a Sweet New Year**

*Yom Kippur
at The Shul*



◆ **THE SHUL** ◆
Welcome Home

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Memberships at The Shul

We'd love to welcome you as "formal" members of our Shul family. Call (414) 228-8000 or e-mail theshul@chabadwi.org for a membership packet. Membership is also online at www.shulcenter.org/join.

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Dear Friend,

Welcome to Yom Kippur Services. The High Holidays are a time of reflection and prayer. This pamphlet is provided as a short explanation as to some of the Jewish customs observed on this day and some holiday insights.

More important than following along with the congregation is that the prayers should be meaningful to you. Therefore, if you find a particular prayer which you like, spend some time pondering and meditating over it. You can always regroup with the congregation later on.

If you cannot stay for the entire service, you should try to attend the prayers of “more importance.” These are Kol Nidrei, Yizkor, the Torah readings, and Ne’ilah. Also, at the conclusion of Ne’ilah there will be a ‘break the fast dinner.’

If you have any questions, please don’t hesitate to ask. We will be more than happy to answer any questions that you may have.

Thank you for joining, and may G-d inscribe and seal you and your family for a happy and sweet year!

Rabbi Shmaya Shmotkin

P.S. Please join us for our year round events and programs.



General Notes

The liturgy for the High Holidays is printed in a special prayer book called the Machzor. The prayer books contain all the prayers recited during these special days, including many which are also recited through the year during the weekday or Shabbat services. The Machzor we use is a bilingual edition, with the Hebrew and the English version sharing the same page numbers. Although the service will be led in Hebrew, Judaism encourages each individual to use the language he or she feels comfortable with. In fact, our English version was specifically designed for this purpose. Feel free to use the version which suits you best. Most of the prayers will be led in Hebrew. In addition, all announcements, commentary, sermons, as well as some individual prayers, will be held in English.

Service Schedule

Sunday, Sept. 27th
4:00pm Mincha

Yom Kippur Evening Services
6:10pm Candle Lighting & Blessing of the Children
6:20pm Kol Nidrei & Kids’ Program
6:35pm Rabbi’s Talk
7:00pm Evening Services

Monday, Sept. 28th
Yom Kippur Morning Services
9:00am Adults’ Morning Services
10:00am Kids’ Program
11:45am Rabbi’s Talk
12:15pm Yizkor
12:30pm Musaf

Yom Kippur Afternoon Services
5:00pm Mincha
6:10pm Neilah Service
7:22pm Shofar Blast, Fast Ends
7:35pm Havdallah and Break Fast

Shabbat, Oct. 3rd
Sukkos Morning Services – Day 1
9:00am Adults’ Morning Services
10:00am Torah Reading, Kids’ Program
11:15am Birkat Kohanim (Priestly Blessings)
11:45am Kiddush in the Sukkah

Sukkos Evening Services – Day 2
7:15pm Evening Services

Sunday, Oct. 4th
Sukkos Morning Services Day 2
9:00am Adults’ Morning Services
10:00am Torah Reading, Kids’ Program
10:00am Lulav Homecoming Parade w/ the Kids
11:15am Birkat Kohanim (Priestly Blessings)
11:45am Kiddush in the Sukkah

Monday, Oct. 5th
Sukkos Under the Stars Community Celebration
5:45pm at Lubavitch House
3109 N. Lake Drive. Featuring Israeli Singer/ Songwriter Ron Eliran in Concert. Cocktails, Soup Bar, & Delicious Buffet Dinner for Adults; Special Menu & Program for the Kids
RSVP & More Info at www.chabadwi.org/sukkos

Wednesday, Oct. 7th
7:30pm Adult Social and Sushi at the Shovers—9190 N. Greenbrook Road, River Hills

Friday, Oct. 9th
Shmini Atzeres Evening Services
6:00pm Evening Services followed by Kiddush in the Sukkah and Dancing with the Torah

Shabbat, Oct. 10th
Shmini Atzeres Morning Services
9:00am Adults’ Morning Services
10:00am Torah Reading, Kids’ Program
10:45am Yizkor
11:15am Birkat Kohanim (Priestly Blessings)
11:45am Kiddush in the Sukkah

Simchas Torah Celebration
6:45pm Candlelighting and Dancing with the Torahs
7:30pm Kiddush Dinner

Sunday, Oct. 11th
Simchas Torah Morning Services
9:00am Morning Services
9:50am Birkat Kohanim (Priestly Blessings)
10:15am Kiddush
11:30am Hafakot Dancing
11:50am Kids Called to Torah
12:20pm Complete and Begin Cycle of Torah Reading
1:10pm Mincha



A Voice from Heaven: Ethics 6:2

By Dovi Scheiner

And the voice called to me from heaven. "Dovi," it said, in an oddly mechanical tone, "just where do you think you're going? Get back on the Hutchinson River Parkway right away!"

Actually, the voice did not originate from heaven. Nor did it address me by my first name. But the part about the "strangely mechanical tone" is perfectly true.

For a drive from my Brooklyn office to a meeting in Rye Brook, New York, I put my vehicle's GPS navigation system to work.



The meeting went well, and it was only on my return drive that I looked up and noticed the exit for Francis Lewis Boulevard. Zomick's, a popular, OK-certified kosher bakery, is located a short distance from Francis Lewis Boulevard on Central Avenue in Long Island. Desperate to populate my desolate stomach, I hooked a quick right at the exit.

That's when it happened. The vehicle's navigation device, which had been supporting my progression along the logical route to my stated destination, took note of my deviation and went berserk. The miniature computer screen, previously displaying a digital map, now started flashing the term "recalculating." Then the orders started coming fast

and furious. First there was, "At the corner, turn left!" When I ignored this, there came, "In a half mile, turn right!" Finally, with an air of urgency, it instructed, "If possible, please make a U turn!"

My thoughts turned back to my days in yeshiva. There was that enigmatic passage in *Ethics of the Fathers*. It spoke of a heavenly voice issuing forth from Mount Horeb (Sinai), imploring errant souls to return to G-d. "Of what use is this heavenly voice," asks the Baal Shem Tov, "if we don't actually hear it on earth?" The Baal Shem Tov explains that while the voice is not physically audible, man's spirit senses it, and many a lost soul has returned at the beck of this powerful call.

Inclined though I was to trust the authenticity of this Torah teaching, the whole scenario seemed somehow farfetched. I mean, does G-d truly monitor every move we make, to the point of registering even the smallest mistake? Is our disobedience to the Divine command taken so seriously as to warrant the raising of a heavenly fuss? And finally, could such otherworldly rumblings realistically register down here on earth?

A right turn in the wrong direction brought me the answer to my questions. Somewhere between the Hutchinson River Parkway and Zomick's Bakery, it became apparent that a remote satellite was attuned to my precise station. One wrong move on my part was enough to elicit an outer space outcry, with this skyway sleuth adjuring me to return to the path of truth.

A new technology reinforced an ancient reality. If a man-made satellite can simultaneously direct tens of thousands of vehicles, why can't G-d direct the many men He made?

Indeed, He does. Sometimes we feel a bolt of inspiration out of the blue, with no prior warning or preparation. It's the heavenly voice ringing out and making the connection. At times, we may even take the hint on a conscious level. Like receiving a call from a friend inviting you to attend a Jewish gathering, or opening your weekly newspaper and encountering a little bit of Torah spirit.

My Body and I: A Fasting Meditation

By Aron Moss

Question:

I understand that fasting on Yom Kippur is supposed to make me focus on my soul rather than my body. But by around lunch time I am so hungry that for the rest of the day all I can think about is food. Doesn't this defeat the purpose? How can I become more spiritual with a growling stomach?

Answer:

Fasting is no fun. By mid-morning on Yom Kippur, we think back to the pre-fast meal and bitterly regret not eating that extra chicken leg. As the day goes on, we begin to glance at our watches every few minutes, desperately anticipating the breaking of the fast. We may be holding a prayer book in our hands, but all we see is a menu in front of our eyes. While the Cantor beseeches G-d to forgive the sinner, we beg Him to give us dinner.

I know of no magic way to make the fast easy. But fasting can certainly be a spiritual experience. Rather than trying to ignore the body's hunger, you can actually use it to bring you closer to your soul. But it takes some contemplation.

When the sounds from your stomach start to drown out the Yom Kippur prayers and you begin to see mirages of food in front of your eyes, try this meditation:

Look at me! I am a mature and reasonable human being, who usually functions pretty well. But today, just because I missed my morning coffee and toast, I can't think straight! Here I am sitting in synagogue on the holiest day of the year, and all I can do is hallucinate about paprika chicken and mashed potatoes. An empty stomach has turned a grown man into a ravenous beast.

And what's even more ridiculous is that in a couple of hours, it will only take a few mouthfuls of cake and a cup of Coke to make me forget the whole ordeal! Is a plate of food all that I amount to? Am I no more than a composite of my dietary intake? If you take away my tuna sandwich, is that the end of me?

The answer is: if your body is all there is, then yes, you are what you eat, and no more. But in truth, your body is not all there is to you. You are much more than the sum of your carbohydrates and proteins. You are not just a body. You are a soul. The body is merely a frail, needy and temporary home for the soul, your true identity.

We take our body and its needs very seriously. We can live our lives pursuing our body's cravings and urges, forgetting that there is more to life than our creature comforts. Fasting is a powerful reminder of the fragility and dependence of the body. The hungrier you get, the more you realize how delicate and unsubstantial the body really is. There must be more to your life than breakfast.

The body is no more than an outer shell, a thin surface level of who you are. Your true identity is the part of you that can see beyond your own hunger and feel the hunger of others; can divert itself away from your own needs and focus on the needs of those around you. That is your soul.

All year we work, shop, cook, eat and exercise to feed our body. One day a year we step back from our bodily self and step into the world of the soul.

On Yom Kippur, become an observer of the body from the point of view of your soul. Watch your body hunger, pity it for its weakness and frailty, and resolve that in the year to come, you will not make your body and its temporal pleasures the be-all-and-end-all of your life. Rather, you will care for your body so it can serve as a vehicle of goodness, to achieve the mission that your soul was sent to this world to fulfill.

An Excerpt from “Tishrei in Ten”

from chabad.org

Yom Kippur

Repair

Your spaceship has been landed and towed into the hangar for repair. But how do you fix a soul?

Screwdrivers won't help. What you need is glue.

You see, fixing a soul is much like fixing a relationship: You need a bond so powerful that all flaws are overlooked and no one has any desire but the good of the other. That's why Yom Kippur is called The Day of At-One-ment: The day that we are at one with our Source Above.

Feasting

Eat two good meals the day before Yom Kippur—it's a mitzvah. In fact, feast today and fast tomorrow and it's counted as though you fasted for two days.

Take lots of fluids and avoid heavy foods. Avoid nuts and other edibles that stick in your teeth.

If you have children, place your hands on each child's head, one at a time, and give each one a blessing.

Forgiving

If someone feels you've wronged him or her, try to make up before the fast. At the same time, forgive the misdemeanors of others against you. According to how you forgive others, that's how G-d forgives you.

Kol Nidre

As the sun kisses the horizon, the cantor's voice pierces our souls with the Kol Nidre. But the most vital prayer—repeated eight times over the 25 hours—is the Vidui. That is when we accept responsibility for every possible human mess-up we may have made, ripping out their residue from within us. It's not easy to remember all of them, so the prayer book provides a list in alphabetical order.

With each Vidui, the soul is freed and climbs higher and higher, until the ultimate high with Neila, which is recited as Yom Kippur is about to come to an end, as the Gates of Heaven begin to close.

On Yom Kippur, after the Torah reading, Yizkor is recited to remember the souls of the departed. We pledge charity on behalf of parents and beloved ones now in the "world of truth." However, the charity cannot be given on Yom Kippur itself, since we do not handle money or write checks on this day.

At the conclusion of Neila, the entire congregation cries out the Shema Yisrael and the shofar is sounded to usher the holiness of the day back to its place—and to announce the incoming holiday (more on that soon).

Fasting

Some think Yom Kippur is a sad day. But how could the highest day of the year possibly be sad?

It's just that dealing with physical needs on this day would be the biggest downer, unplugging that connection and hurling us back into the mundane world.

That's also why we dress in white on this day, to remind us that today we are as high as the angels, who need neither food nor drink. And yet higher.

Finishing

As soon as Yom Kippur is over, we return home for a joyous feast. We wish each other "Good Yom Tov!" According to the Baal Shem Tov, we are now in the purest day of the year, since all the souls are clean and shiny like new.



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As I continued my prayers throughout the day, with my anger and inability to forgive foremost in my mind, the words in my prayer book began to transform from pleas for forgiveness to instructions on how to forgive. Could it be that on this Yom Kippur, G-d was teaching me how to forgive Him? Were these words lessons on forgiveness from the Master of Forgiveness?

The instructions seemed clear: Forgive for the sake of forgiveness. Forgive not because there is a reason that you understand (for you may never understand My ways) nor because I deserve it (for the ways that I manifest are often terrible and frightening). Forgive solely out of love, so we can be close once again. Forgive because you, created in My image, are also a forgiver. I created you with that capacity so that always, no matter what happens in your life, you and I can be close, so that you and whomever you love, despite what transpires between you, can always reunite and begin again, clean and pure, ready for a new start.

The message and instructions were there and I began to hear through the prayers G-d speaking to me, reaching out for reconciliation, waiting for my forgiveness, providing instruction on how to forgive Him.

Again I remembered my friend's provocative e-mail. No, G-d was not crawling. But was He begging? Was He beseeching me for forgiveness and reconciliation? Was our unity more important to Him than any sin I had committed against Him or any pain He had inflicted upon me?

Still, I could not do it. Even seeing the extent to which He was reaching out to me, I was incapable of forgiveness. Though I wanted to forgive, on this day of truth, I saw that I could not. What He had done to me remained too terrible, too intentional to forgive.

As the closing Ne'ilah prayer approached, I was in despair. It all seemed hopeless. When I presented my case before my invisible set of internal judges I carry with me, I was judged right, He guilty. He deserved my distance and rejection and I would stubbornly and righteously continue it.

As the sun began to set I felt completely alone. The loneliness was intolerable.

The feeling reminded me of times when I argue with my wife. We fight about some injustice or hurt that has occurred. I present my case before my internal judges and I am proven right. I withdraw in righteousness, punish her with rejection and distance. Sometimes it will last a few hours, sometimes a couple of days. But finally, the loneliness sets in. The distance becomes unbearable. The withdrawal demands an end. My desire for reconciliation and reunification overpowers any need to be right or to punish. And so, without needing to even speak about what it was we were fighting about, eventually we forgive each other so that we can be together again, loving again, carrying on our lives and relationship and family in good will and with a fresh start. We don't forgive because of any reason, nor out of our acceptance of each other's human pettiness or frailty or imperfection. We forgive simply from the desire to love and reunite. Simply so we can be together again. So that things will be the way they should.

And in the last minutes of Yom Kippur, out of my unbearable loneliness and separation from G-d, I found my ability to forgive. I forgave simply so that we -- G-d and I -- could be close again. So that we would return to the unity that is meant to be between us. Out my love for Him, my need of Him, my inability to carry on without Him I found the capacity somewhere in me. I reached out to Him in forgiveness and in that moment the pain and blame began to recede.

For me, Yom Kippur has not ended. This forgiveness business is not so easy as to be learned and actualized in a day. My anger and resentment, frustration and intolerance still flare, still cause damage. On my bad days it is hard for me to accept all that is happening, changing, challenging my life. But some new dynamic has entered the process. A softening. An acceptance. A letting go. A.... forgiveness.

For, you see, the last thing I want during the fragility of this time in my life is to be separate from G-d or from those whom I love or from the rising sun or a star-filled night.

I don't want anger and blame to ruin any moment of my life nor rend me from the unity with which G-d has created the world and that only I have the power to destroy.

Thankfully, G-d has provided me with the capacity to forgive and, now, in these days since Yom Kippur, he has provided me with the opportunity to reveal that forgiveness. He knows that both He and I, and all those that He and I love, will eventually, continuously do unforgivable things to each other. And despite the pain we will cause each other, we will need to forgive each other.

To not forgive would be an unbearable breach of the unity of creation.

Forgiveness

By Jay Litvin

These were the days before Yom Kippur. I was lonely and couldn't figure out why. The loneliness had been there for months.

Things were good with my wife and kids. I'd been on the phone with my sisters and in close contact with my friends.

So, what was the source of this loneliness?

I was missing G-d.

I was and had been feeling distant from Him. A strange feeling for me. Even in my late teens I had been able to connect with Him when I needed to. He always answers my calls. Sometimes I don't even need to call. I just feel his companionship as I journey through life.

But these last months had been lonely. I had been separate from Him, unable even to call out. And I didn't know why.

Just before Yom Kippur, I received an e-mail from a friend. He's not a religious Jew, though we discourse often about G-d and Torah. He's a writer and has a way with words. We also share the same disease, and talk much about our symptoms, history, fears, treatments and aches. There's a special something that happens with people who share the same disease. We never have to worry about boring each other. All our concerns and obsessions about the daily changes in our health or symptoms, our latest internet discoveries about new cures and clinical trials may bore others, but are continuously fascinating to us.

At the end of this email my friend wrote: "Jay, this Yom Kippur, I don't think you should go to shul and ask G-d for forgiveness. This Yom Kippur you should stay home and G-d should come crawling on His knees and beg you to forgive Him for what He's done to you."

When I read these lines I laughed. My friend is a sacrilegious provocateur. He believed what he said, but he mainly wrote those words to shock me. I filed his words, but paid them little attention.

As Yom Kippur drew close, I continued to wonder what was taking place between G-d and me. I worried that this day of prayer and fasting would be void of the usual connection that Yom Kippur brings.

And then in a flash I realized that I was angry at G-d. And had been for some time. I was angry about my disease and I was angry that I was not yet healed. I was angry about my pain. And I was angry at the disruption to my life, the fear, the worry and anxiety that my disease was causing my family and those who loved and cared about me. I was angry about the whole thing, and He, being the boss of everything that happens in the world, was responsible and to blame.

And so, I entered Yom Kippur angry at G-d.

I put on my kittel and my tallit and I went to shul. I had received permission from my doctors and rabbi to fast. I beat my chest and listed my sins. I asked forgiveness. And yet, no matter how long the list of sins was, no matter how much I sought forgiveness, I could not find any act so heinous as to deserve the punishment that I felt was being inflicted upon me.

I prayed for G-d's forgiveness, and in my prayer book I read the words that promised His forgiveness. He would forgive me, I read, because that was His nature. He is a forgiver. He loves me. He wants me to be close to Him. And so He forgives me not for any reason, not because I deserve it, but simply because that is who He is. He is merciful and forgives and wipes the slate clean so that we -- He and I -- can be close again for the coming year.

I read these words, nice words, yet my anger remained.

Then I again remembered the email. In his cynicism, my friend had hit the mark: I needed to forgive G-d. I needed to rid myself of my anger and blame for the sickness He had given me. I needed to wipe the slate clean so that He and I could be close once again.

But how? On what basis should I forgive Him? If He was human, I could forgive Him for His imperfections, His fallibility, His pettiness, His upbringing, His fragility and vulnerability. I could try to put myself in His shoes, to understand His position. But He is G-d, perfect and complete! Acting with wisdom and intention. How could I forgive Him?!

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The Sukkah

Rehearse

Sukkot is an eight-day holiday with three special mitzvahs:

- To dwell in a sukkah
- To hold the Four Species (see The Four Kinds for more on this)
- To be happy (yes, that's also a mitzvah)
- The first two and the last two days are Yom Tov, when work is forbidden. During the five days in between, for the most part work is permitted, albeit with certain restrictions.

The Sukkah

"For seven days, all Jewish people should live in sukkahs, in order that all your generations will remember that I had the Jewish People living in sukkahs when I took them out of Egypt." —The Five Books of Moses, Book III (Leviticus)

"The sukkahs were the clouds of glory that surrounded and protected us." —The Talmud

Now your spaceship's bright and spiffy and ready to fly. But in order to stay connected during this year's odyssey, best you first rehearse the steps in a controlled environment.

That's the sukkah; an all-encompassing, embryonic, virtual world where whatever you do is a mitzvah. Eat, you're doing a mitzvah. Talk, you're doing a mitzvah. Just sit there—you're powerfully connected from head to toe.

Upon release from this immersive environment, you'll treat the big world the same way: Discovering how everything you do is another way to connect to the Infinite. Which is the whole idea of Torah.

How to do the sukkah thing:

Before Sukkot, construct a temporary, 3–4 walled structure directly under the sky—no trees or overhang above. For roofing, toss on any cut, inedible vegetation that will last for seven days. Favorites are western cedar, bamboo and corn husks (without the corn). Use enough to provide more shade than sunlight. Time-hungry? There are pre-fab sukkah kits that go up in a matter of minutes—just make sure your walls are secure and firm. Check with a salted sukkah-dweller for more details.

For seven days, make the sukkah your official home. Don't panic: As long as you eat your meals there, you're okay. But try to include anything else that you would normally do in the house—like reading a book or talking with a friend.

Fill your sukkah with guests, enjoy great meals, sing songs, tell stories and speak words of Torah wisdom. Every night of Sukkot invite one of the Seven Shepherds of Israel, in this order: Abraham, Isaac, Jacob, Moses, Aaron, Joseph and David.

On the first night of Sukkot, regardless of weather conditions, make kiddush and eat at least part of the meal in the sukkah. The rest of Sukkot, if the weather gets awful, you can leave the sukkah. After all, you would leave your own house if the roof were leaking buckets, wouldn't you?

Each time you leave the sukkah and return to eat a grain-based meal, say a blessing:

Ba-ruch A-tah Ado-nai E-lo-he-nu Me-lech ha-olam a-sher ki-de-sha-nu be-mitz-vo-tav ve-tzi-va-nu le-shev ba-sukkah.
[Blessed are You, L-rd our G-d, King of the universe, who has sanctified us with His commandments, and commanded us to sit in the Sukkah.]



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The Four Kinds

Reunite

"On the first day, take the fruit of the etrog tree, unopened fronds of the date palm, myrtle branches and willows of the brook and rejoice before G-d, your G-d for seven days." —The Five Books of Moses, Book III

Each one of us discovers a small corner of some galaxy, but together we perceive the wonders of an entire universe. So now, get networked—with your Arba Minim ("Four Kinds") device.

Here, four very diverse floras create one integral whole. If one is missing—even a humble willow branch—the circuit is broken. Just like us, the Jewish People: Regardless of knowledge or observance, each individual is unique and essential.

How to do the Arba Minim thing:

Easier than eating cake: The lulav (palm branch) comes wrapped with three myrtle branches and two willow bush branches. Hold those in your right hand and say the following blessing:

Ba-ruch A-tah Ado-nai E-lo-he-nu Me-lech ha-olam a-sher ki-de-sha-nu be-mitz-vo-tav ve-tzi-va-nu al netilat lulav.

[Blessed are You, L-rd, our G-d, King of the universe, who has sanctified us with His commandments and has commanded us concerning the taking of the lulav.]

Now pick up the etrog (stem down) in your left hand.

First time this year? Then say the blessing for new things:

Ba-ruch A-tah Ado-nai E-lo-hei-nu me-lech ha-olam she-heche-ya-nu ve-ki-yi-ma-nu ve-higi-a-nu liz-man ha-zeh

[Blessed are You, Lord our G-d, King of the universe, who has granted us life, sustained us, and enabled us to reach this occasion.]

Hold the etrog together with the other three species. You did it.
Repeat every day of Sukkot excluding Shabbat.

The custom, however, is to wave the arba minim three times in all six directions: Face east and wave three times to the south, three to the north, three east, three up, three down and finally, three west (over your shoulder).

Hoshana Rabba

The seventh day of Sukkot is when the global rain factor is set. We circle the Torah reading table in the synagogue seven times with the arba minim while reciting special prayers, and then beat a bundle of five willow branches on the floor. You have a better way to make it rain?



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Shemini Atzeret

Rejoice & Refuel

"On the eighth day will be a withholding for you. You shall do no burdensome work." —The Five Books of Moses

Why is it called a with holding? Because G-d is like a king who hosts a seven-day party. When everyone is about to leave, he holds back his closest friend and says, "It's hard for us to part. Stay another day and we'll party with whatever is left." —The Talmud

What drives a Jew to take on the entire world and be different no matter what? Guilt can be pretty powerful, but as we have seen today, it's not always effective. The Baal Shem Tov revealed a far better fuel: The power of joy.

That's why, for Chassidim, the greatest celebration of the year is the last two days of the High Holiday season, Shemini Atzeret & Simchat Torah, days dedicated to the joy of being a Jew.

Details:

One more day to eat in the sukkah—but without the Leshev BaSukkah blessing. We make a holiday kiddush and enjoy a festive meal at night and by day. Shemini Atzeret begins the prayer for rain. Yizkor is also said.

On the first night of Shemini Atzeret, we do hakafot (explanation coming up). As with every holiday, we do no work.



Simchat Torah

Recycle

Now to the control room for a debriefing. That's when you get called up to the Torah and we read from its final verses. Then, for instructions on your upcoming mission, we begin reading the Torah again from "In the beginning"—to remind you that whatever you see out there, all of it extends from a single oneness called G-d.

Hakafot

The Five Books of Moses are divided into 53 portions, called parshas. Each week, we read one parsha, completing the entire scroll every year. The cycle begins on the last Shabbat of the month of Tishrei and ends on Simchat Torah.



To celebrate, on the night of Simchat Torah, we take out all the Torah scrolls from their ark, parade with them around the reading table seven times—and dance and sing with them. The next morning, we call everyone for a turn as we conclude the Torah reading. Then we sing and dance with the Torah again.

Go find another people that dances with a book. But for Jewish people, Torah is not just a book to study, it is life. For over 3300 years, we have held tight to it, despite all odds, and it has kept us in existence. On Simchat Torah, they say, the Torah itself wants to rejoice—and we provide the legs.